UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

State • 2011



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • State • 2011

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. A statement that although seemingly contradictory or absurd may be well founded or true is a(n)

   A) antiphrasis.
   B) equivoque.
   C) oxymoron.
   D) paradox.
   E) paraleipsis.

2. A short lyric usually dealing with love or a pastoral theme and designed for—or at least suitable for—a musical setting is a(n)

   A) aubade.
   B) ballad.
   C) madrigal.
   D) masque.
   E) paean.

3. A figure of speech characterized by strongly contrasting words, clauses, sentences, or ideas is a(n)

   A) antithesis.
   B) aphorism.
   C) apostrophe.
   D) apposition.
   E) axiom.

4. A kind of primer common in England from the sixteenth to the eighteenth centuries, which usually consisted of a sheet of paper or vellum mounted on a board and covered with a transparent material for protection, is known as a(n)

   A) commonplace book.
   B) hornbook.
   C) jest book.
   D) omnibus.
   E) palimpsest.

5. Associated with science fiction and the absurdist novel, the author who wrote *Slapstick*, *The Sirens of Titan*, *Player Piano*, *Cat's Cradle*, *Breakfast of Champions*, and *Slaughterhouse-Five* is

   A) Ray Bradbury.
   B) Günter Grass.
   C) Joseph Heller.
   D) Thomas Pynchon.
   E) Kurt Vonnegut, Jr.

6. The braggart or impostor in Greek comedy is the

   A) alazon.
   B) deuteragonist.
   C) eiron.
   D) gerontion.
   E) tritagonist.

7. The German-born Swiss national, author of *Siddhartha*, and recipient of the 1946 Nobel Prize for Literature is

   A) Günter Grass.
   B) Hermann Hesse.
   C) Elfriede Jelinek.
   D) Thomas Mann.
   E) Nelly Sachs.

8. Not one of the standard book sizes understood in terms of folding foolscap is

   A) duodecimo.
   B) folio.
   C) octavo.
   D) quarto.
   E) volume.

9. The term applied to any collection of poems, romances, or epics that are usually traditional accumulations sharing a theme and acquiring literary form through a succession of authors rather than a single author is

   A) cycle.
   B) episodic structure.
   C) framework-story.
   D) leitmotif.
   E) montage.

10. The group of writers organized in 1714 by Jonathan Swift to satirize both literary incompetence and the "false taste of the age" is known as the

    A) Goliardic poets.
    B) Grub Street poets.
    C) Literary Club.
    D) Satanic School.
    E) Scriblerus Club.

11. The 1971 Pulitzer Prize for Drama was awarded to the author of the novel *The Pigman* for his compelling play *The Effect of Gamma Rays on Man-in-the-Moon Marigolds*,

A) Edward Albee.
B) Charles Fuller.
C) David Mamet.
D) Neil Simon.
E) Paul Zindel.

12. Literary criticism that is based on the philosophical theory that argues that value is based on labor, that class struggle forms the basic pattern in history, and that political and economic power will inevitably be seized by the proletariat is

A) analytical criticism.
B) Marxist criticism.
C) New Criticism.
D) practical criticism.
E) theoretical criticism.

13. An episode of which the circumstances are so strongly foreseen that the writer is seemingly required to include it is called a(n)

A) dumb show.
B) intentional fallacy.
C) *mot juste*.
D) obligatory scene.
E) stock scene.

14. The process of returning a metaphorical expression to its original meaning, as recognized in a description of someone who was killed by arrows as being someone "catching his death," is called

A) recantation.
B) recension.
C) redaction.
D) reification.
E) reliteralization.

15. The eponymic term derived from the Greek orator Demosthenes' speeches against the father of Alexander the Great that now applies to any harangue or bitter speech is

A) billingsgate.
B) gasconade.
C) philippic.
D) polemic.
E) robinsonade.

16. Verse, including most English-language verse, that depends on both the number of syllables per line and the pattern of accented and unaccented syllables for its rhythm is

A) accentual-syllabic verse.
B) alliterative verse.
C) blank verse.
D) free verse.
E) quantitative verse.

17. Theaters and acting companies organized during the 1660s by Davenant and Killigrew and given special privileges by Charles II and that continued in some form until their virtual monopolies were revoked in 1843 are the

A) kabuki theaters.
B) Little Theaters.
C) patent theaters.
D) private theaters.
E) public theaters.

18. Formal satire in which the speaker attacks vice and error with contempt and indignation is known as

A) Horatian satire.
B) Juvenalian satire.
C) Menippean satire.
D) Parnassian satire.
E) Varronian satire.

19. Not one of Greek philosophy's four natural virtues to which were later added the biblically inspired faith, hope, and love to create the seven cardinal virtues is

A) fortitude.
B) humility.
C) justice.
D) prudence.
E) temperance.

20. The author of *The Tragedy of Pudd'nhead Wilson*, *Innocents Abroad*, *Roughing It*, *The Prince and the Pauper*, and *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court* is

A) Willa Cather.
B) Samuel Clemens.
C) William Faulkner.
D) Ellen Glasgow.
E) Bret Harte.

21. The descriptive term that, when used narrowly, suggests a certain hypocrisy or squeamishness regarding both the use of profanity and the inclusion of sex in, among other art forms, literature is
A) Calvinistic.
B) gothic.
C) hedonistic.
D) vatic.
E) Victorian.

22. An inappropriateness of speech resulting from the use of one word for another word that resembles it is known as a(n)
A) eggcorn.
B) howler.
C) malapropism.
D) mondegreen.
E) spoonerism.

23. The 1954 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry was awarded to the author of a collection of mostly free verse entitled *The Waking*,
A) Elizabeth Bishop.
B) Kate Chopin.
C) Sylvia Plath.
D) Theodore Roethke.
E) Henry Taylor.

24. The group of critics, including Georges Poulet, Albert Béguin, and Marcel Raymond, who see a literary work as a series of existential expressions of the author's individual consciousness is the
A) Geneva School.
B) Imagists.
C) New Critics.
D) Parnassians.
E) Symbolists.

25. Not among the authors whose work constitutes the oldest body of literature, both oral and written, on the North American continent is
A) Louise Erdrich.
B) N. Scott Momaday.
C) Mary Rowlandson.
D) Leslie Marmon Silko.
E) E. Donald Two-Rivers.

26. The author of *The Golden Apple*, *Delta Wedding*, the short story collection *A Curtain of Green*, and the novel for which she received the 1973 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction, *The Optimist's Daughter*, is
A) Alison Lurie.
B) E. Annie Proulx.
C) Marilynne Robinson.
D) Anne Tyler.
E) Eudora Welty.

27. Low comedy involving physical action, practical jokes, and such actions as pie-throwing and pratfalls is known as
A) burlesque.
B) comedy of humours.
C) comic relief.
D) slapstick.
E) travesty.

28. The British author of *The Magus*, *The Collector*, and his internationally acclaimed metafictional novel *The French Lieutenant's Woman* is
A) John Fowles.
B) William Golding.
C) Graham Greene.
D) Salman Rushdie.
E) Evelyn Waugh.

29. A perfect example of the link sonnet, which is by definition a three-quatrain sonnet whose quatrains are connected by repeating rhymes, namely *abab*, *bcbc*, *cdcd*, is the
A) caudate sonnet.
B) curtal sonnet.
C) Petrarchan sonnet.
D) Shakespearean sonnet.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

30. The term coined in 1731 to catalogue a work that chronicles someone's endeavor to survive after being shipwrecked on a desert island is
A) charade.
B) gasconade.
C) harlequinade.
D) pasquinade.
E) robinsonade.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with Eugene O'Neill's *The Hairy Ape*.
Items 37-43 are associated with Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice*.
Items 44-50 are associated with Theodore Roethke's poetry (selected).

31. Paddy, during his extensive monologue in the first scene of O'Neill's *Hairy Ape*, contrasts the "day that's gone" to the "hell of the stokehole," where the firemen are "caged in by steel," thus effectively offering a(n)
    A) analogy.
    B) exposition.
    C) foreshadowing.
    D) malediction.
    E) prolepsis.

32. The indifference that characterizes the social class toward whom Long has engendered in Yank a deep contempt is best symbolized in the
    A) bus's not having stopped.
    B) churchgoers' mechanical unawareness of Yank.
    C) churchgoers' shared "I beg your pardon."
    D) gentleman's standing unmoved as if Yank hadn't hit him.
    E) woman's ignoring Yank's invitation to the old boiler.

33. Yank's estimation of all whom he meets is, ironically,
    A) they all have simian qualities.
    B) they are all capitalists.
    C) they are all socialists.
    D) they don't belong.
    E) they should be in cages.

34. Mildred's sarcastic response, "The inanities?" to her aunt's admonition, "[Y]ou are quite free to indulge any pose of eccentricity that beguiles you—as long as you observe the amenities—" constitutes a(n)
    A) idiotism.
    B) malapropism.
    C) regionalism.
    D) spoonerism.
    E) wellerism.

35. The stockers' referring to Paddy as Caruso Pat is both a compliment and a stereotyping of Paddy's ethnicity and his ability to
    A) consume alcohol.
    B) sing tenor.
    C) stoke the fires of cruise ships.
    D) tell tall tales.
    E) womanize.

36. The assessment of the Wobblies in Senator Queen's calling the organization a "menace against the very-life-blood of the American Eagle" is countered in *The Hairy Ape* by
    A) the I.W.W. secretary's reaction to Yank.
    B) Long's calling the bourgeoisie "bleedin' parasites."
    C) Mildred's grandfather's having started as a puddler.
    D) Paddy's refusal to report to watch.
    E) Yank's willingness to blow up "de woiks."

37. In Austen's *Pride and Prejudice*, accepting Darcy's marriage to Lizzy in order to "retain the right of visiting at Pemberley" is motivation enough for
    A) Mrs. Bennet.
    B) Caroline Bingley.
    C) Catherine de Bourgh.
    D) Georgiana Darcy.
    E) Charlotte Lucas.

38. Entailment is a problem for the Bennets because
    A) Mrs. Bennet has a brother.
    B) Collins marries Charlotte Lucas.
    C) Longbourn is entailed on the male line.
    D) Longbourn is located in Derbyshire.
    E) Longbourn is located in Hertfordshire.

39. The cautious observation that "[t]houghtlessness, want of attention to other people's feelings, and want of resolution" might bring about misery is made by
    A) Elizabeth Bennet.
    B) Jane Bennet.
    C) Catherine de Bourgh.
    D) William Collins.
    E) Fitzwilliam Darcy.

40. Mr. Bennet's denigrating remark, "It is happy for you that you possess the talent of flattering with delicacy," is directed at
    A) Elizabeth Bennet.
    B) Mr. Bennet himself.
    C) Mrs. Bennet.
    D) William Collins.
    E) Fitzwilliam Darcy.

41. Austen's narrator observes that his "character was decided. He was the proudest, most disagreeable man in the world, and every body hoped that he would never come there again." This generalization is directed at

A) Charles Bingley.
B) William Collins.
C) Fitzwilliam Darcy.
D) William Lucas.
E) George Wickham.

42. Ultimately, the successful fulfillment or completion of anything of importance in the world Austen has constructed relies not on social convention but on

A) kinship.
B) language.
C) prejudice.
D) pride.
E) wealth.

43. The truism with which Austen begins *Pride and Prejudice*, arguably one of the most famous opening lines in all of narrative fiction, directs the readers' attention to the

A) amount of money it takes to get married.
B) conditions married men must avoid.
C) number of eligible bachelors in the area.
D) problems associated with having so many sisters.
E) role mothers must play.

Items 44-47 refer to Theodore Roethke's

I Knew a Woman

I knew a woman, lovely in her bones,
When small birds sighed, she would sigh back at them;
Ah, when she moved, she moved more ways than one:
The shapes a bright container can contain!
Of her choice virtues only gods should speak,
Or English poets who grew up on Greek
(I'd have them sing in chorus, cheek to cheek.) 7

How well her wishes went! She stroked my chin,
She taught me Turn, and Counter-turn, and Stand;
She taught me Touch, that undulant white skin:
I nibbled meekly from her proffered hand;
She was the sickle; I, poor I, the rake,
Coming behind her for her pretty sake
(But what prodigious mowing we did make.) 14

Love likes a gander, and adores a goose:
Her full lips pursed, the errant note to seize;
She played it quick, she played it light and loose;
My eyes, they dazzled at her flowing knees;
Her several parts could keep a pure repose,
Or one hip quiver with a mobile nose 20
(She moved in circles, and those circles moved.)

Let seed be grass, and grass turn into hay:
I'm martyr to a motion not my own;
What's freedom for? To know eternity.
I swear she cast a shadow white as stone.
But who would count eternity in days?
These old bones live to learn her wanton ways:
(I measure time by how a body sways.) 28

44. Roethke's "I Knew a Woman," in both its tone and imagery, suggests the

A) aubade.
B) elegy.
C) lament.
D) ode.
E) pastoral.

45. The opening line, "I knew a woman, lovely in her bones," is a fine example of (the)

A) chiasmus.
B) parallelism.
C) pyramidal line.
D) rhopalic line.
E) zeugma.

46. Thematically, Roethke's persona relies on his careful choice of words, especially the ambiguity that manifests itself repeatedly as

A) double entendre.
B) hyperbole.
C) oxymoron.
D) synecdoche.
E) understatement.

47. Line 25, "I swear she cast a shadow as white as stone," offers a fine example of

A) chiaroscuro.
B) hyperbole.
C) litotes.
D) sfumato.
E) tautology.

Items 48-50 refer to Theodore Roethke's

The Right Thing

Let others probe the mystery if they can.
Time-harried prisoners of *Shall* and *Will*—
The right thing happens to the happy man.

The bird flies out, the bird flies back again;
The hill becomes the valley, and is still;
Let others delve that mystery if they can.

God bless the roots!—Body and soul are one!
The small become the great, the great the small;
The right thing happens to the happy man.

Child of the dark, he can out leap the sun,
His being single, and that being all:
The right thing happens to the happy man.

Or he sits still, a solid figure when
The self-destructive shake the common wall;
Takes to himself what mystery he can,

And, praising change as the slow night comes on,
Wills what he would, surrendering his will
Till mystery is no more: No more he can.
The right thing happens to the happy man.

48. The happiness to which Roethke's "Right Thing" refers suggests a conscious shift from absolute delight in the body's interaction with nature to the

A) empirical.
B) existential.
C) metaphysical.
D) phenomenological.
E) transcendental.

49. The occurrence in close proximity of the words *happens* and *happy* is known as

A) epanalepsis.
B) haplography.
C) polyptoton.
D) symploce.
E) tautology.

50. The verse form of Roethke's poem approaches the

A) *chant royal*.
B) *rime couée*.
C) rondeau.
D) *terza rima*.
E) villanelle.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-54 refer to Shakespeare's

Sonnet 22

My glass shall not persuade me I am old
So long as youth and thou are of one date;
But when in thee time's furrows I behold,
Then look I death my days should expiate.
For all that beauty that doth cover thee
Is but the seemly raiment of my heart,
Which in thy breast doth live, as thine in me;
How can I then be elder than thou art?
O therefore, love, be of thyself so wary
As I, not for myself, but for thee will,
Bearing thy heart, which I will keep so chary
As tender nurse her babe from faring ill.
Presume not on thy heart when mine is slain:
Thou gav'st me thine not to give back again.

51. Shakespeare's persona's fanciful notion that he and the other to whom the poem is addressed have exchanged hearts constitutes a

A) conceit.
B) dead metaphor.
C) euphemism.
D) kenning.
E) simile.

52. A strong example of reification highlights

A) line 2.
B) line 3.
C) line 7.
D) line 9.
E) line 11.

53. In order to accommodate the poem's metrical pattern, line 4 relies on

A) enjambment.
B) inversion.
C) litotes.
D) metathesis.
E) parenthesis.

54. Death will expiate, put an end to, his days when

A) the furrows are plowed.
B) the mirror cracks.
C) the nurse has taken care of her babe.
D) the object of his love grows old.
E) the seemly raiment covers his heart.

Items 55-58 refer to Dante Gabriel Rossetti's

Sudden Light

I have been here before,
But when or how I cannot tell:
I know the grass beyond the door,
The sweet keen smell,
The sighing sound, the lights around the shore.

You have been mine before,
How long ago I may not know:
But just when at that swallow's soar
Your neck turned so,
Some veil did fall, I knew it all of yore.

Has this been thus before?
And shall not thus time's eddying flight
Still with our lives our love restore
In death's despite,
And day and night yield one delight once more?

55. The visual, auditory, and olfactory imagery of Rossetti's first stanza are nicely linked by

A) alliteration.
B) assonance.
C) consonance.
D) dissonance.
E) synaesthesia.

56. The sense of déjà vu that pervades the persona's memory is emphasized by his feeling of being at a threshold in time, a state known in literature as

A) aesthetic distance.
B) divine afflatus.
C) interlude.
D) liminality.
E) vatic.

57. The poem's total effect depends on the convention

A) *carpe diem*.
B) *memento mori*.
C) *ubi sunt*.
D) *vade mecum*.
E) *verbum infans*.

58. The quality of elusive certainty is enhanced by

A) catharsis.
B) gigantism.
C) mixed figures.
D) rhetorical questioning.
E) sarcasm.

Items 59-62 refer to William Meredith's

The Illiterate

Touching your goodness, I am like a man
Who turns a letter over in his hand
And you might think that this was because the hand
Was unfamiliar but, truth is, the man
Has never had a letter from anyone;
And now he is both afraid of what it means
And ashamed because he has no other means
To find out what it says than to ask someone.

His uncle could have left the farm to him,
Or his parents died before he sent them word,
Or the dark girl changed and want him for beloved.
Afraid and letter-proud, he keeps it with him.
What would you call his feeling for the words
That keep him rich and orphaned and beloved?

59. The form of Meredith's "The Illiterate" is the

A) caudate sonnet.
B) curtal sonnet.
C) English sonnet.
D) Italian sonnet.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

60. The intensity of the poet-persona's bewilderment depends on his use of a(n)

A) epic simile.
B) epiphany.
C) flyting.
D) oxymoron.
E) pun.

61. The subject, arguably the tenor, of the sonnet is

A) the dark girl.
B) goodness.
C) the letter.
D) the persona.
E) shame.

62. The theme reflects the paradoxical power of

A) goodness.
B) illiteracy.
C) language.
D) love.
E) mail.

Items 63-64 refer to Robert Creeley's

Oh No

If you wander far enough
you will come to it
and when you get there
they will give you a place to sit

for yourself only, in a nice chair,
and all your friends will be there
with smiles on their faces
and they will likewise all have places.

63. The impact of Robert Creeley's "Oh No" depends on
A) bathos.
B) hyperbole.
C) invective.
D) irony.
E) litotes.

64. Ultimately, the didactic message of Creeley's poem is found in the ambiguity of
A) line 1.
B) line 3.
C) line 4.
D) line 6.
E) line 8.

Item 65 refers to Robert Pinsky's

ABC

Any body can die, evidently. Few
Go happily, irradiating joy,

Knowledge, love. Most
Need oblivion, painkillers,
Quickest respite.

Sweet time unafflicted,
Various world:

X = your zenith.

65. The verse form that Pinsky's "ABC" represents perfectly is the
A) abecedarian.
B) acrostic.
C) clerihew.
D) mesostich.
E) none of the above.

The required Tie-Breaking Essay prompt is found on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.

Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three pages of blank paper have been provided for this essay; however, it is not expected that the essay will be longer than 150 words; however, the essay should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than a few sentences.

Read E. E. Cummings's "my sweet old etcetera," and offer a discussion addressing the attitudes and understandings that give rise to the tone that characterizes the persona's comment on war and "participation" in war.

my sweet old etcetera

my sweet old etcetera
aunt lucy during the recent

war could and what
is more did tell you just
what everybody was fighting

for,
my sister

isabel created hundreds
(and
hundreds)of socks not to
mention fleaproof earwarmers
etcetera wristers etcetera, my
mother hoped that

i would die etcetera
bravely of course my father used
to become hoarse talking about how it was
a privilege and if only he
could meanwhile my

self etcetera lay quietly
in the deep mud et

cetera
(dreaming,
et
cetera, of
Your smile
eyes knees and of your Etcetera)

2nd _____ _____

1st _____ _____
score initials

University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest

ANSWER SHEET

Contestant # _____ Conference # _____

Please write answers as CAPITAL letters.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. _____	11. _____	21. _____
2. _____	12. _____	22. _____
3. _____	13. _____	23. _____
4. _____	14. _____	24. _____
5. _____	15. _____	25. _____
6. _____	16. _____	26. _____
7. _____	17. _____	27. _____
8. _____	18. _____	28. _____
9. _____	19. _____	29. _____
10. _____	20. _____	30. _____

number correct _____ x 1 pt each = _____

Part 2: UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

31. _____	38. _____	45. _____
32. _____	39. _____	46. _____
33. _____	40. _____	47. _____
34. _____	41. _____	48. _____
35. _____	42. _____	49. _____
36. _____	43. _____	50. _____
37. _____	44. _____	

number correct _____ x 2 pts each = _____

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism **15 items (2 points each)**

51. _____	56. _____	61. _____
52. _____	57. _____	62. _____
53. _____	58. _____	63. _____
54. _____	59. _____	64. _____
55. _____	60. _____	65. _____

number correct _____ x 2 pts each = _____

total points

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KEY

Page numbers are those associated with the *Handbook* 10e, the Penguin 1996 edition of *P&P*, and the Vintage edition of *The Hairy Ape*.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History

30 items (1 point each)

1.	D	376	11.	E	633	21.	E	543
2.	C	308	12.	B	312	22.	C	309
3.	A	35	13.	D	360	23.	D	630
4.	B	260	14.	E	440	24.	A	235
5.	E	2, 472, 614	15.	C	392	25.	C	574
6.	A	11	16.	A	4	26.	E	629
7.	B	626	17.	C	383	27.	D	488
8.	E	69, 545	18.	B	286	28.	A	319, 610-12
9.	A	140	19.	B	481	29.	E	296
10.	E	474	20.	B	593	30.	E	453

Part 2: UIL Reading List

20 items (2 points each)

31.	C	149	38.	C		45.	C	426
32.	D	180	39.	A	134	46.	A	166
33.	D		40.	D	67	*47.	A or B	264
34.	B	155 (*HB* 309)	41.	C	13	48.	C	322
35.	B	144	42.	B		49.	C	405
36.	A	184, 190-93	43.	E		50.	E	544
37.	B	366	44.	E	381			

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism

15 items (2 points each)

51.	A	116	56.	D	295	61.	D	
52.	B	440	57.	C	534	62.	C	
53.	B	280	58.	D	448	63.	D	282
54.	D		59.	D	283	64.	A	
**55.	A or B	13	60.	A	193	65.	E	

*While the line is, indeed, hyperbolic, the imagery, which involves chiaroscuro, is arguably as important as the hyperbole.

** Both alliteration and assonance (as an internal patterning) inform the imagery of the lines in question.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on E. E. Cummings's "my sweet old etcetera"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

allusion,
ambiguity,
cliché,
connotation,
denotation,
double entendre,
diction,
free verse,
irony,
internal rhyme,
parenthesis,
satire,
setting,
syntax,
theme,
tone, and
white space.

The contestant should recognize a continuum that begins with aunt lucy's programmed naïveté and continues through to the persona's self(?)-remove, through fantasy, from the reality of war. The traditional attitudes toward war, as represented in the persona's references to his immediate family, are handled as cliché misunderstandings of the deep horror of war: knitting socks and earwarmers. His parents' seemingly casual acceptance of the likelihood of his death might be recognized as an embedded allusion to Owen's "Dulce et Decorum Est." The young writer might sense satire at work.

What might well be a letter home directly references the women in the persona's life (perhaps in contrast to the woman to whom he is speaking/writing) and conclusively points to an irony, one that Aeschylus played with so long ago in *Lysistrata:* women are expected to bear and nurture children only to have them die in war. The women of his family—ready to defend the rationale for war, handcraft creature comforts, and recognize the potential for his dying bravely (thus honorably)—are apparently oblivious to the psychological/emotional/physical need for the essentiality of woman as life-giver and comforter and source of beauty against the backdrop of, among all else, war.